

Fig. 2.2: The Ganga river near Patna

Whichever way we look at it, what makes this first description of the city so spot on is that it captures its essence. The lifeblood of the urban metropolis of Pataliputra, as we shall see, was the web of connections, political and commercial, that inextricably bound it to regions and people, near and far, making it a place whose history extended much beyond the city walls that enclosed it. It also underlines the fact that whatever became its purported past by the time it was visited by Buddhist pilgrims from China, the historical origins of this city and its consolidation as a political capital had nothing to do with the family or the line of kings to which Ashoka belonged.

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What did Pataliputra, which was an integral part of his early years, look like around the time Ashoka was born? In the late third century BCE, when